

Christian metaontology: doctrinal disputes that turned on words

Terms, pronunciations, what was at stake, and whether it was ever settled

Date	Terms and question	Resolution
325–381	homoousios · homoiousios · homoios hoh-moh-OO-see-os · hoh-moy-OO-see-os · hoh-MOY-os Homoousios means of the same substance. Homoiousios means of like substance. Homoios means only similar. The first two differ by a single letter in Greek. The question was whether Christ is of the same substance as the Father. Arius taught that the Son was the first and greatest of God's creatures, made out of nothing before time began, so there was a point at which the Son did not exist. Athanasius answered that a created savior cannot save. <i>Athanasius, Arius, Basil of Ancyra</i>	Settled. Nicaea adopted the first term; contested for two generations, ratified at Constantinople 381. Arian belief survived among Germanic peoples into the 7th century.
c. 360–381	ousia · hypostasis OO-see-ah · hy-POSS-tuh-sis Ousia and hypostasis both meant something close to being or substance in ordinary Greek, and the anathema attached to the Nicene creed used them as synonyms. That left theologians with no way to say that God is one in some respect and three in another, since they had only one idea and two words for it. The Cappadocians fixed this by assigning ousia to what God is, of which there is one, and hypostasis to who God is, of which there are three. <i>Basil of Caesarea, Gregory of Nazianzus, Gregory of Nyssa</i>	Settled. Became the standard formula. Latin rendered hypostasis as persona, because its literal cognate substantia meant the wrong thing.
431	theotokos · christotokos thee-oh-TOH-kos · kris-toh-TOH-kos Theotokos means God-bearer and christotokos means Christ-bearer. Both were proposed as the proper title for Mary. Nestorius preferred Christ-bearer, holding that Mary bore the man Jesus, in whom God dwelt, rather than the eternal God himself. Cyril answered that a mother bears a person and not a nature, and the person she bore was God; deny the title and the child born was not God at all. <i>Cyril of Alexandria, Nestorius</i>	Partly. Ephesus affirmed God-bearer and deposed Nestorius. The Church of the East never accepted it and remains separate, though a 1994 joint declaration with Rome found the underlying faith the same.
451–553	physis · mia physis sesarkomene FY-sis · MEE-ah FY-sis seh-sar-koh-MEH-nee Physis means nature, the whole set of properties that makes something the kind of thing it is. The Council of Chalcedon held that Christ is one person in two natures, so that he is fully God and at the same time a complete human being with a human body, mind, and will. Its opponents held that the divine and human fused at the incarnation into a single new nature, because a nature is what an actual thing has and Christ is one thing. Both sides quoted a phrase of Cyril's, mia physis sesarkomene, which means one incarnate nature of God the Word. He died in 444 and never had to say which reading he intended. <i>Chalcedon, Dioscorus, Severus of Antioch</i>	Unresolved. Permanent schism with the Oriental Orthodox. Joint declarations from 1973 onward concluded the difference is largely terminological, but communion has not been restored.

Date	Terms and question	Resolution
c. 500	<i>apophatic · kataphatic</i> ap-oh-FAT-ik · kat-uh-FAT-ik Kataphatic means speaking about God by affirming things, and apophatic means speaking about God by denying them. The problem behind both is that every word we have was learned from creatures. So the kataphatic approach says what scripture and creation permit, that God is good and wise and powerful, and the apophatic approach then takes each of those back, holding that God is not good in any sense we can grasp, not one being among others, not even existent in the way ordinary things are. These are two methods rather than two parties, and most theologians use both. <i>Pseudo-Dionysius</i>	Never a controversy. Both retained as complementary. The East leans harder on denial, and Palamas later built directly on it.
c. 645	<i>ekporeusis · processio</i> ek-por-YOO-sis · pro-CHESS-ee-oh Ekporeusis is the Greek word the creed uses for the Spirit's coming forth from the Father, and processio is the Latin word used to translate it. They do not mean quite the same thing. The Greek word is reserved for coming forth from an ultimate origin, while the Latin covers any coming-forth, including one that passes through an intermediary. So when Latins said the Spirit proceeds from the Father and the Son, Greeks heard a claim that the Trinity has two first causes. Maximus explained that the Latins meant the Son as a channel and not as a source. <i>Maximus the Confessor, later Photius</i>	Unresolved. Rome's 1995 clarification affirmed the Father as sole source, but the clause stays in the Western creed. Anglicans have voted to drop it without doing so.
649–681	<i>energeia · thelema</i> en-ER-gay-ah · THEH-lay-mah Thelema means will, and energeia means operation or activity, what a nature actually does. The question was whether willing belongs to a nature or to a person. The imperial party proposed that Christ has only one will, offered as a compromise to win the miaphysite provinces back. Maximus objected that if Christ has no human will, then his human nature is missing something every other human being has, and the prayer in Gethsemane becomes theater. <i>Maximus the Confessor, Sergius of Constantinople</i>	Settled. Third Constantinople defined two wills and two operations. Maximus, mutilated and exiled, died in 662 and was vindicated nineteen years later.
1215–1274	<i>substantia · accidentia</i> sub-STAHN-tsee-ah · ahk-chee-DEN-tsee-ah Substantia means what a thing fundamentally is, and accidentia means the properties you can see, taste, and weigh. The distinction comes from Aristotle. Transubstantiation holds that at the consecration the substance of the bread becomes the body of Christ while the accidents remain those of bread. The doctrine depends entirely on the distinction being real, since otherwise the claim is either about nothing observable or plainly false. <i>Fourth Lateran Council, Aquinas</i>	Settled for Rome only. Trent affirmed transubstantiation as the apt term in 1551. Rejected by every Reformation tradition.

Date	Terms and question	Resolution
c. 1270–1300	<i>analogia entis · univocatio entis</i> ah-nah-LOH-gee-ah EN-tees · oo-nee-voh-KAHT-see-oh EN-tees Analogia entis means analogy of being and univocatio entis means univocity of being. Both are answers to a question about the word exists. When you say that God exists and that a chair exists, is the word doing the same job in both sentences? Aquinas said no, only a proportional likeness, because God's existing is not one instance of a general category that also contains chairs. Scotus said that if the word changes meaning entirely, the sentence conveys nothing and no argument about God can be valid. <i>Aquinas, Duns Scotus; later Przywara, Barth</i>	Never adjudicated. No council ruled. Still live: Barth in 1932 named analogy of being as the one thing keeping him from Rome.
1341–1351	<i>ousia · energeiai</i> OO-see-ah · en-ER-gay-eye Ousia here means God's essence, God as he is in himself, and energeiai means God's energies, his activity as it reaches outward into the world. Monks on Mount Athos claimed to see the uncreated light of the Transfiguration during prayer. Palamas defended them by arguing that what they encounter is the energies, which are genuinely God and not a created substitute, while the essence remains permanently beyond reach. Barlaam answered that this divides God into a knowable part and an unknowable part, which gives you either two gods or none. <i>Gregory Palamas, Barlaam of Calabria</i>	Settled for the East. Three Constantinopolitan councils upheld Palamas, and the distinction is now binding Orthodox doctrine. Never received in the West.
1529	<i>est · significat</i> est · sig-NIF-ee-kaht Est is the Latin word for is, and significat is the Latin word for signifies. The argument was over which one Jesus meant when he said “this is my body” at the Last Supper. Luther held the verb literal and would not move off it. Zwingli read it as a figure of speech, the way “I am the vine” is a figure of speech, and argued that a body seated at God's right hand cannot also be present on ten thousand altars. <i>Luther, Zwingli</i>	Failed at the time. Marburg agreed on fourteen of fifteen articles and broke on this one, splitting Lutheran from Reformed. The Leuenberg Agreement of 1973 finally restored communion in Europe.
1941–1980	<i>mythos · kerygma</i> MY-thos · keh-RIG-muh Mythos means the picture of the world the Christian message arrived wrapped in, with a heaven overhead, an underworld below, and demons moving through the middle. Kerygma means the proclamation itself, the thing being announced. Bultmann argued that a modern person cannot believe the first and that it has to be stripped away to reach the second. The question that followed is blunter. When a creed says that God made heaven and earth, is that a report about how things actually are, or is it a declaration of where the speaker stands? <i>Bultmann, Flew, D. Z. Phillips, Cupitt</i>	Open. No institutional adjudication, and none likely. Churches have mostly declined to rule on what their own language is doing.

Two caveats. The story of Luther chalking the words on the table at Marburg comes from later accounts rather than the contemporary record, and is best treated as tradition. And the phrase both sides quoted at Chalcedon, which Cyril believed came from Athanasius, in fact originates with Apollinarius, whose Christology the Church had already condemned. Pronunciations throughout follow English academic convention rather than reconstructed ancient Greek, and Latin terms are given in the Italianate ecclesiastical form.